Improving the user experience of an AI-powered travel planning platform

Evaluative UX Research Study

Executive Summary

As a UX Research Intern at Wilson Wings, I led a 9-week mixed-methods study with 53 participants to evaluate the usability of Travlo, an AI-powered travel planning app. The research combined user interviews, moderated usability testing, and feature evaluation to assess how users experienced AI-driven itinerary generation (Bobo AI), destination discovery, budgeting, and booking. The study found strong enthusiasm for AI-assisted planning, but surfaced significant friction around choice overload, redundant features, slow AI response times, and booking reliability — issues that, if addressed, could meaningfully improve task completion and user trust.

1. Project Overview

Travlo is an AI-powered travel planning application that helps users discover destinations, generate personalized itineraries, manage budgets, and book travel services through its AI assistant, Bobo AI. I was brought in as a UX Research Intern to conduct an evaluative study assessing how well the platform's AI-driven features support real travel-planning tasks.

Role: UX Research Intern, Wilson Wings
Research type: Evaluative UX research (mixed methods)
Participants: 53 users across varied age groups and travel experience levels
Duration: 9 weeks
Methods: User interviews, moderated usability testing, feature evaluation, qualitative analysis

2. Problem Statement

Travlo offers a broad set of AI-powered planning features, but the product team lacked clarity on how these features performed in practice. The research was designed to answer:

- How do users perceive the AI-driven planning experience?
- Can users successfully navigate the platform and complete core tasks?

- Which features provide the most value to users?
- What usability issues prevent users from completing travel-planning tasks?

3. Research Objectives

- Evaluate the usability of Travlo's core features.
- Understand user perceptions of Bobo AI and AI-generated trip planning.
- Identify friction points during itinerary creation and booking.
- Gather recommendations for future product improvements.

4. Methodology

4.1 Participants

53 participants were recruited across different age groups and travel experience levels, including a significant proportion of university students interested in AI-assisted travel planning.

4.2 Research Activities

Each session combined contextual interviews with moderated, task-based usability testing. Participants were asked to:

- Explore destinations using the discovery feature.
- Generate an AI-powered travel plan with Bobo AI.
- Create a travel experience/itinerary.
- Search for accommodations.
- Book transportation services.
- Reflect on overall usability and satisfaction afterward.

Sessions were analyzed for behavioral patterns, feature adoption, and points of frustration, then synthesized using thematic analysis to identify recurring issues across the participant base.

5. Quantitative Highlights

In addition to the 53-participant evaluative study, supplementary feedback was collected via targeted Google Form surveys and follow-up interviews with smaller user groups to validate specific issues. Key data points:

- 3 of 5 respondents (ages 19–21) reported that the 'Explore AI Curated Feed' module felt functionally identical to 'Plan with AI', with 2 of these explicitly stating only one of the two features is necessary.
- 5 of 5 respondents (ages 20–32) using the 'Book Now' module requested additional transport options (bus/train) beyond flights.
- 1 of 5 respondents in the same group specifically flagged the booking confirmation step as confusing.
- Bobo AI's itinerary generation, expected to take ~3 minutes, failed to complete even after 10+ minutes for multiple users attempting the 'Generate Experience' step confirmed via direct testing.
- 100% (3 of 3) of middle-aged users (35–40) surveyed found the app difficult to use overall, citing the Discover Trip module and excessive trip-type preferences as key pain points.
- Users in the 40–75 age range, primarily planning pilgrimage trips, consistently identified language support (e.g., Telugu, Kannada, Tamil, Malayalam) as their primary barrier to adoption.

6. Key Findings

6.1 AI-Powered Planning Generated Strong Interest

Participants responded positively to Bobo AI's ability to generate travel recommendations based on personal preferences and budget constraints. Users particularly valued:

- Personalized trip suggestions tailored to stated preferences.
- Automated itinerary generation that reduced manual planning effort.
- Budget-aware recommendations.
- An overall reduction in time spent planning.

6.2 Adoption Varied Significantly by Age

Participants aged 19–23 adapted quickly to the interface and explored multiple features confidently. Participants over 30 experienced more friction, frequently reporting:

- Information overload when presented with multiple options at once.
- Difficulty distinguishing between similar features.
- Higher cognitive effort and longer task completion times.

6.3 Contextual Trip Information Increased Perceived Value

Users responded well to supplementary information surfaced during trip generation, including weather insights, expense estimates, transportation costs, and food/accommodation budgets. This context helped users feel more confident evaluating their options.

6.4 Visual Design Was Well Received

Participants described the app as visually appealing and modern, with intuitive navigation between primary sections and a clear information hierarchy that built confidence in the product.

7. Pain Points

7.1 Choice Overload During Trip Planning

The most frequently reported issue was the sheer number of options presented during trip creation. Participants described the process as overwhelming, said excessive preference settings increased decision fatigue, and noted that planning required more effort than they expected from an "AI-assisted" tool.

7.2 Feature Redundancy Created Navigation Confusion

Several modules appeared to offer overlapping functionality. Participants struggled to determine which module to use for a given task, could not clearly distinguish between planning-related features, and were uncertain about the intended end-to-end workflow leading to inefficient navigation.

Fig. 1 — 'Plan trip with Bobo' and 'Explore AI curated feed' appear as separate home-screen tiles, despite users perceiving them as the same feature.

7.3 AI Response Times Affected Satisfaction

When itinerary generation took longer than expected, participants interpreted the delay as system unreliability or poor performance rather than normal AI processing time. In follow-up testing, Bobo AI's 'Generate Experience' step expected to take roughly 3 minutes failed to complete even after 10+ minutes for multiple users, directly preventing task completion.

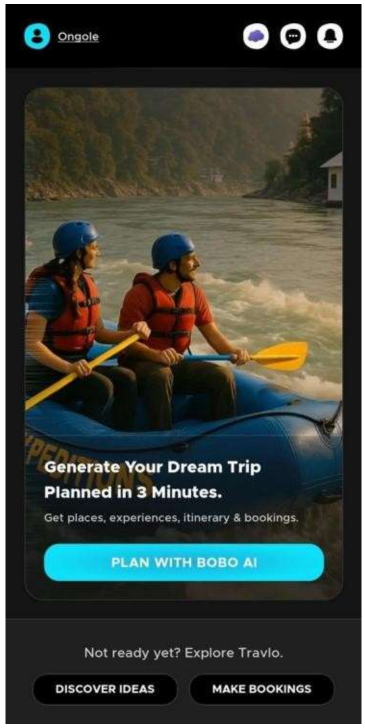

Fig. 2 — The 'Plan with Bobo AI' screen promises a trip plan in 3 minutes; in testing, this step did not complete even after 10+ minutes, undermining trust in the AI experience.

7.4 Search and Booking Issues Reduced Trust

Participants encountered difficulties searching for specific or less common destinations, and experienced booking failures within the Stays module. These reliability issues had a direct negative impact on user confidence in the platform.

7.5 Language Barriers Limited Adoption Among Older Users

Users aged 40–75, primarily planning pilgrimage trips across India, consistently cited the lack of regional language support (e.g., Telugu, Kannada, Tamil, Malayalam) as their main barrier to using the app, alongside discomfort with English-only interfaces.

8. Recommendations

Based on participant feedback and observed behavior, I recommended the following improvements, prioritized by impact:

8.1 Simplify the Trip Creation Workflow

Reduce the number of choices presented at once and progressively disclose advanced options, directly addressing the most common pain point (choice overload).

8.2 Consolidate Overlapping Features

Merge or clearly differentiate modules with redundant functionality to improve discoverability and reduce navigation confusion.

8.3 Improve AI Response Times and Feedback

Optimize itinerary generation performance and add clear loading states/progress indicators so delays are not perceived as system failure.

8.4 Strengthen Search and Booking Reliability

Expand the destination database to better cover less common locations and resolve booking failures in the Stays module to rebuild user trust.

8.5 Introduce Train Booking

Expand transportation options to include train booking alongside existing flight and bus services, aligning with observed user travel preferences.

8.6 Create Student-Focused Travel Packages

Offer pre-built, budget-conscious itineraries tailored to university students a segment that showed high engagement with AI-assisted planning.

8.7 Introduce Community Reviews

Allow travelers to share reviews and experiences for destinations to help future users make more informed decisions and increase trust in recommendations.

8.8 Add Multi-Language Support

Introduce regional language support (e.g., Telugu, Kannada, Tamil, Malayalam) to serve older users — particularly those planning pilgrimage trips for whom language was the primary adoption barrier.

9. Impact

This research validated strong user demand for AI-powered travel planning while surfacing critical usability issues affecting task completion and satisfaction. The findings gave the product team actionable, prioritized recommendations to:

- Improve feature discoverability and reduce navigation confusion.

- Increase booking completion rates by resolving reliability issues.
- Strengthen user trust in AI-generated recommendations.
- Enhance overall satisfaction, particularly for less tech-confident user segments.

10. Reflection

This project gave me end-to-end ownership of an evaluative research study from planning research activities and moderating sessions with 53 participants, to synthesizing qualitative findings into prioritized, actionable recommendations. It strengthened my ability to identify usability patterns across diverse user segments, translate behavioral observations into productrelevant insights, and communicate findings in a way that supports clear product decision-making.